

SHOGI · VARIANT 8 OF 24

Chu Shogi

12×12
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

Chu Shogi

Chu Shogi (将棋, Middle Shogi). First documented ~1350 AD. The dominant form of chess in Japan for centuries until modern Shogi replaced it.

OVERVIEW

Chu Shogi is played on a 12×12 board with 46 pieces of 21 different types per side. Unlike modern Shogi, there are no drops. The defining piece is the **Lion**, a double-move piece so powerful that special rules govern its capture to prevent quick trades.

Win condition: Capture all of the opponent’s royal pieces. There is no check or checkmate — the game continues until the last royal is captured. Stalemate is assumed to be a win for the side delivering it.

STARTING SETUP

Pieces are listed by file (a–l = left to right from White’s perspective) and rank. White occupies ranks 1–5, Black mirrors on ranks 8–12.

RANK 1 (BACK RANK)

SQUARE	PIECE	MOVEMENT (BETZA)
a1, l1	Lance	fR (forward slide only)
b1, k1	Ferocious Leopard	FvW (diagonal step + vert. step)
c1, j1	Copper General	fFvW (fwd diagonal + vert. step)
d1, i1	Silver General	FfW (diagonal + fwd step)
e1, h1	Gold General	WfF (orthogonal + fwd diagonal)
f1	King	K (one step any direction)
g1	Drunk Elephant	FfsW (diagonal + fwd/side step)

RANK 2

SQUARE	PIECE	MOVEMENT (BETZA)
a2, l2	Reverse Chariot	vR (vertical slide only)
c2, j2	Bishop	B (diagonal slider)
e2, h2	Blind Tiger	FbsW (diagonal + back/side step)
f2	Kirin	FD (diagonal step + Dabbaba leap)
g2	Phoenix	WA (orthogonal step + Alfil leap)

RANK 3

SQUARE	PIECE	MOVEMENT (BETZA)
a3, l3	Side Mover	sRvW (sideways slide + vert. step)
b3, k3	Vertical Mover	vRsW (vert. slide + side step)
c3, j3	Rook	R (orthogonal slider)
d3, i3	Dragon Horse	BW (Bishop + ortho. step)
e3, h3	Dragon King	RF (Rook + diagonal step)
f3	Lion	KNAD (see below)
g3	Queen	Q (Rook + Bishop)

RANKS 4–5

SQUARE	PIECE	MOVEMENT
a4–l4	Pawn	fW (forward single step)
d5, i5	Go Between	vW (vertical step, either direction)

KEY PIECES

LION

The Lion makes up to **two moves per turn**, independently in any direction (even changing direction after the first). It may:

- ♦ Move or capture to any square within a 5×5 area around it
- ♦ Capture a piece, then move or capture again as a King
- ♦ Move to an adjacent empty square and return (passing the turn)
- ♦ Hop over a square (if moving to the same destination in one leap, with the middle square occupied)

KIRIN

Leaps diagonally one square (Ferz) OR leaps exactly two squares orthogonally (Dabbaba). Promotes to **Lion**.

PHOENIX

Moves one square orthogonally (Wazir) OR leaps exactly two squares diagonally (Alfil). Promotes to **Queen**.

DRUNK ELEPHANT

Moves one step diagonally in any direction, or one step forward/sideways orthogonally (cannot step backward). Promotes to **Prince** (a second King).

PROMOTION

Promotion is **optional** and occurs when a piece **enters** the promotion zone (the four ranks farthest from the player: ranks 9–12 for White). A piece can also promote when it **captures** inside the zone. Each piece may promote **at most once** regardless of its position.

Pawns may promote even without a capture upon reaching the last rank.

King, Lion, and Queen do not promote.

PIECE	PROMOTES TO	PROMOTED MOVE
Pawn	Gold General	WfF
Gold General	Rook	R
Rook	Dragon King	RF
Dragon King	Soaring Eagle	RbBfFfA + limited Lion power fwd
Silver General	Vertical Mover	vRsW
Vertical Mover	Flying Ox	BvR
Copper General	Side Mover	sRvW
Side Mover	Free Boar	BsR
Ferocious Leopard	Bishop	B
Bishop	Dragon Horse	BW
Dragon Horse	Horned Falcon	BbsRfWfD + limited Lion power fwd
Lance	White Horse	vRfB
Reverse Chariot	Whale	vRbB
Blind Tiger	Flying Stag	FbWfsW
Drunk Elephant	Prince (royal)	K
Go Between	Elephant (= Drunk Elephant)	FfsW
Phoenix	Queen	Q
Kirin	Lion	KNAD

Horned Falcon and **Soaring Eagle** have limited Lion power in one/two directions respectively: they may make two consecutive steps along the same ray, continuing after a capture.

PRINCE (TWO ROYAL PIECES)

A Drunk Elephant that promotes becomes a **Prince** — a second royal King. When a player has two royals, losing one is non-fatal; only losing the **last** royal loses the game.

LION CAPTURE RESTRICTIONS

To prevent quick Lion trades, two rules apply:

- 1 **No protected trade:** A Lion may not capture a protected enemy Lion if doing so exposes it to recapture (as if it were an absolute royal for one move).
 - ♦ Exception: A Lion may always capture an adjacent enemy Lion (which could take it “in passing” regardless).
- ♦ Exception: A Lion capturing the enemy Lion together with at least one other non-trivial piece (not a Pawn or Go Between) may do so even if exposed to recapture.
- 1 **Counter-strike rule:** A non-Lion may not capture the enemy Lion if on the immediately preceding turn the enemy captured a friendly Lion using a non-Lion.
 - ♦ Exception: Promotion to Lion during such a capture allows the fresh Lion to be recaptured.

REPETITION RULES

Repeating a position (same side to move) is forbidden. Per the Japanese Chu Shogi Association:

- ♦ Perpetual check: the checking side must vary.
- ♦ If only one side is attacking with all moves since the prior occurrence, the attacker must vary.
- ♦ If both sides are only passing, the side that began passing must vary.
- ♦ If neither side attacks anything, a draw may be claimed.
- ♦ Otherwise, the side whose move caused the repetition loses.

(Rules trigger on the 4th repetition, as in modern Shogi.)

BARING RULE

King + any piece vs. lone King is a win, by convention, for the stronger side. Some interpretations extend this to a full bare-king rule (any pieces remaining = win), but this is disputed.

Source: chessvariants.com/rules/chu-shogi (H.G. Muller)